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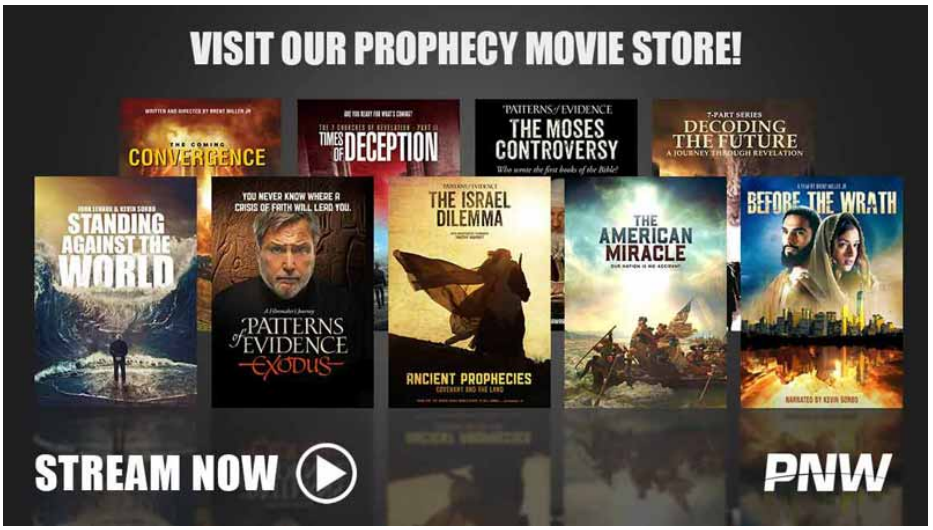
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ARTICLE

The LGBT Identity Boom Is Reversing - What Changed?



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 12, 2026

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For years, Americans were told that the dramatic rise in LGBT identification among young people represented an unstoppable cultural transformation. Each new generation would be more sexually fluid, more willing to reject traditional labels, and more likely to embrace identities that previous generations had rarely discussed.

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But something unexpected is happening among America's youngest teenagers. The numbers are moving in the opposite direction — and the decline is dramatic.

According to an analysis of federal survey data by San Diego State University psychology professor Jean Twenge, the percentage of ninth-grade girls identifying as lesbian or bisexual fell from 30% in 2021 to just 17% in 2025. Even more striking, the percentage identifying specifically as bisexual dropped from 26% to 13% — a 50% decline in only four years.

Across all ninth-graders, lesbian, gay, or bisexual identification reportedly fell from 17% in 2023 to 11% in 2025. Older teenagers showed much smaller changes, suggesting that whatever is happening may be particularly significant among the youngest members of Generation Z and those following behind them.

Twenge described the decline as looking like a "free fall," while acknowledging that its causes remain unclear.

That uncertainty deserves attention. But so does a question that few people were asking when the numbers were rapidly climbing: What if part of America's teenage sexual identity explosion was shaped by cultural influences that are now beginning to change?

When Sexual Identity Became A Cultural Obsession

It is difficult to overstate how dramatically American culture changed its messaging toward children over the past decade.

Television programs, streaming services, celebrities, social media influencers, corporate advertising, and educational institutions increasingly placed sexual

identity at the center of conversations about personal authenticity.

Young people were encouraged to explore their identities, question traditional assumptions, and view sexuality as an essential component of discovering who they really were.

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For many teenagers, particularly girls navigating the already confusing years of adolescence, the message was nearly impossible to escape.

The internet introduced an expanding vocabulary of sexual identities, while social media communities offered affirmation, belonging, and recognition around those labels. In some online environments, discovering a new identity became a major personal milestone, complete with public announcements and enthusiastic support.

Adolescence is a period when peer acceptance, social expectations, and the language available to describe personal experiences can exert enormous influence.

It is therefore reasonable to ask whether the extraordinary rise in bisexual identification reflected changing cultural expectations about how teenagers understood and described themselves.

And if those expectations are changing again, perhaps the survey numbers are beginning to reflect it.

Is The Rainbow Culture Losing Its Influence?

Consider the timing.

The dramatic increase in LGBT identification coincided with an era in which sexual identity became one of the most celebrated and politically charged subjects in American public life.

Pride celebrations expanded. Corporations adopted rainbow branding. Schools became battlegrounds over sexual identity and gender ideology. Entertainment companies increasingly made LGBT representation a central part of their programming.

At the same time, social media amplified conversations about sexuality to an unprecedented degree.

But cultural movements can experience fatigue, particularly when something once presented as countercultural becomes an established expectation.

Could some younger teenagers be growing tired of the constant emphasis on labels? Are they less interested in turning every uncertainty about attraction or relationships into a declaration of identity? Has the cultural pressure surrounding these subjects begun to weaken?

We do not yet know.

The CDC survey cannot tell us whether the decline reflects changing attitudes, social pressures, patterns of disclosure, or some combination of factors. And today's teenagers still remain more likely to identify as lesbian, gay, or bisexual than teenagers did before the pandemic.

Nevertheless, the reversal challenges the assumption that the previous trajectory could only continue upward.

For years, rising identification was frequently interpreted as evidence of permanent social change. Now that the numbers are falling among younger teenagers, those same cultural assumptions deserve closer examination.

The Deeper Problem: A Generation Searching For Identity

There is an even larger issue beneath these statistics.

Modern American culture has increasingly encouraged young people to define themselves through sexuality, political beliefs, personal feelings, and social categories.

The question "Who am I?" has too often been reduced to "Which label describes me?"

But labels, whatever their significance to an individual, cannot answer the deepest questions of human existence.

They cannot explain why a person has value, what gives life meaning, or where genuine hope can be found.

For Christians, the answer begins somewhere entirely different.

Genesis 1:27 teaches that human beings are created in the image of God. Human dignity is not earned through sexual identity, popularity, social acceptance, or cultural approval. It is inherent in the fact that every person bears the image of the Creator.

Romans 12:2 warns believers not to be conformed to the patterns of this world but to be transformed through the renewing of their minds.

That message is especially relevant to a generation immersed in algorithms, influencers, and rapidly changing social expectations.

The Christian understanding of identity does not begin with discovering which cultural category offers the greatest affirmation. It begins with understanding who God is, what He has revealed, and what it means to live according to His truth.

And that message must be communicated with both conviction and compassion. Young people wrestling with questions about sexuality are not political talking points. They are individuals deserving of dignity, patience, and genuine care.

An Opportunity The Church Cannot Afford To Miss

If the newest figures represent the beginning of a broader cultural shift, Christians should resist the temptation to treat them simply as a political victory.

A decline in LGBT identification does not automatically mean a rise in biblical convictions, church attendance, or Christian faith.

A teenager who no longer identifies as bisexual has not necessarily embraced traditional marriage, rejected secular ideology, or discovered the Gospel.

Those are entirely separate questions.

But the changing numbers may create an opportunity to challenge the assumption that identity politics represents the inevitable future of American youth.

For years, the cultural message to teenagers was that discovering themselves required questioning inherited beliefs, challenging traditional boundaries, and finding a sexual identity that expressed their authentic selves.

Now, among the youngest teenagers, that narrative appears less dominant than it was just a few years ago.

Perhaps this is a temporary fluctuation. Perhaps the numbers will stabilize. Or perhaps we are witnessing the early stages of a generation growing less interested in defining itself through the categories that dominated the previous decade.

Whatever the explanation, the church has something far more enduring to offer than the latest cultural trend.

Young people do not need another fashionable identity to tell them they matter. They need to know that they were created with purpose, that truth exists beyond personal feelings, and that their ultimate hope is found not in discovering a label but in knowing Jesus Christ.

The LGBT identity boom may be reversing. Whether that becomes a genuine spiritual turning point will depend on something far more important than the next set of survey numbers: whether Christians are prepared to offer a generation searching for meaning the truth it has been missing.



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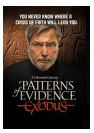
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